

PSY405 - Lesson 20

What is the Humanistic View?

Humanistic psychology says:

- people are basically good
- people have free choice
- people want to grow and improve
- life has meaning and purpose

It focuses on positive sides of life rather than problems only.

Important terms

Free choice

Ability to decide for yourself instead of being controlled by others or instincts.

Personal growth

Improving yourself mentally, emotionally, socially, and morally over time.

Abnormality

Psychological problems like unhealthy thinking, behavior, or emotions.

Humanistic explanation of abnormal behavior

Humanistic psychologists say:

- problems come when people avoid taking responsibility for their actions and thoughts
- society sometimes pushes people in unhealthy directions
- humans are not born bad

Example:

If a person keeps blaming others for anger issues, never accepts their mistakes, and refuses to change, humanistic psychologists say the problem is lack of responsibility, not evil nature.

Is Maslow a humanistic psychologist?

Yes. Abraham Maslow is one of the main humanistic psychologists.

He created the **Hierarchy of Needs**.

Maslow's Hierarchy of Needs

Maslow said humans have different levels of needs. They are arranged like steps of a pyramid. Lower needs must be met first, then higher ones appear.

From bottom to top:

1. physiological needs
2. safety needs
3. love and belongingness
4. self esteem
5. self actualization

Meaning of each term with examples

Physiological needs

Basic survival needs

Food, water, sleep, oxygen

Example

A hungry student will think about food more than exams.

Safety needs

Feeling safe and protected

House, job security, protection from danger

Example

A person in war worries about safety before education.

Love and belongingness

Need for relationships

Family, friends, acceptance, affection

Example

A student may feel lonely without friends even if grades are good.

Self esteem needs

Feeling respected and confident

Achievement, recognition, success

Example

Winning a medal increases confidence.

Self actualization

Reaching full potential

Becoming the best version of yourself

Example

Quaid e Azam, Dr Abdul Salam, Javed Miandad reached very high potential.

Maslow said:

Many people stay at lower levels. Very few reach self actualization.

Why can't everyone become self actualized?

Because

- basic needs are hard to fulfill for many people
 - some people face poverty, stress, or lack of education
 - some lose confidence
 - some stop trying
 - society sometimes blocks growth
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Important Concepts in Humanistic Psychology

1. Individual as an integrated whole

You are seen as a complete person
mind, emotions, body, social life, values
all together, not in separate parts.

2. Irrelevance of animal research

Humanistic psychologists say animals are too different from humans, so animal experiments cannot fully explain human personality.

3. Inner nature of humans

Humans are naturally good, loving, and creative from inside.

4. Human creative potential

Every person has the ability to create ideas, art, plans, or solutions.

What are self-actualizers like?

Maslow studied highly developed people and found common characteristics.
Here are main ones in simple words with examples.

1. Efficient perception of reality

They see reality as it truly is, not as they wish.

Example: Accepting failure and learning instead of denying it.

2. Acceptance of self and others

They accept their mistakes and weaknesses without hating themselves.

Example: Saying "I am not perfect but I can improve."

3. Spontaneity and naturalness

They behave naturally, not to impress others.

4. Problem centered

They focus on meaningful goals or missions in life.

5. Need for privacy

They enjoy alone time and are comfortable being by themselves.

6. Autonomy

They depend on inner strength, not only on society's approval.

7. Freshness of appreciation

They enjoy small things daily, like sunsets or good food, without boredom.

8. Peak experiences

Moments of deep joy, inspiration, or spiritual feeling.

9. Social interest

They care for humanity and want to help others.

10. Deep relationships

They have fewer but stronger friendships.

11. Democratic attitude

They respect everyone and learn from anyone.

12. Clear sense of right and wrong

Strong moral values.

13. Philosophical humor

They enjoy thoughtful humor, not insulting humor.

14. Creativeness

They think originally like children do.

15. Resistance to enculturation

They do not blindly follow society's pressure.

Important point

Self actualizers are not perfect saints.

They can also be

angry, irritated, jealous, sad, stubborn, or moody.

They are still human.

Goal of psychotherapy in humanistic psychology

Therapy should help a person return to the path of self growth and self actualization by:

- understanding themselves
 - accepting feelings
 - making better life choices
 - developing confidence
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Short summary in very simple words

Humanistic psychology says:

- people are basically good
- people have free will
- growth and self development are very important
- society sometimes causes problems
- Maslow explained needs from basic survival to full potential
- very few people reach full self actualization

SHORT QUESTIONS

Q1: What is Humanistic Psychology?

Answer:

Humanistic psychology is a branch of psychology that emphasizes the positive aspects of human life, free choice, personal growth, and self-development. It focuses on the whole person, not just their problems, and assumes that humans are naturally good. Human behavior results from the voluntary choices people make, rather than being controlled entirely by society, instincts, or unconscious forces.

Explanation:

Humanistic psychologists see humans as active agents capable of improving themselves. They are different from behaviorists (who focus only on observable actions) and psychoanalysts (who focus on unconscious drives). They care about mental health, happiness, creativity, and self-improvement.

Example:

A student who decides to work on personal weaknesses instead of blaming teachers or classmates demonstrates humanistic principles.

Tips:

- Remember: focus is on **growth, free will, and positivity**.
 - Key thinkers: **Abraham Maslow, Carl Rogers**.
 - Use **“whole person”** idea in answers.
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Q2: How does Humanistic Psychology explain abnormal behavior?

Answer:

Humanistic psychology suggests that abnormal behavior occurs when a person refuses to take responsibility for their own actions, thoughts, or feelings. It is not because humans are naturally bad but because society or personal choices prevent growth.

Explanation:

If someone blames external circumstances for anger, stress, or aggression, humanistic psychologists would see this as avoiding responsibility. Abnormality is a result of stopping personal growth or avoiding self-understanding.

Example:

Someone always blaming coworkers for their own mistakes at work instead of reflecting and improving is showing humanistic abnormality.

Tips:

- Key term: **Abnormality = unhealthy or unhelpful behavior**.
 - Think in terms of **responsibility and growth**.
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Q3: Who was Abraham Maslow, and why is he important in Humanistic Psychology?

Answer:

Abraham Maslow (1908–1970) was a humanistic psychologist who created the **Hierarchy of Needs**, a theory showing that humans must fulfill basic needs before achieving higher goals like self-actualization (realizing full potential). He focused on healthy individuals instead of only studying psychological problems.

Explanation:

Maslow believed humans are naturally good and want to grow. His hierarchy explains human motivation: people first meet survival needs and gradually reach higher levels of achievement and personal growth.

Example:

A person cannot focus on creativity (high-level need) if they are hungry or unsafe (low-level needs).

Tips:

- Always mention **“self-actualization at the top”** in answers.
 - Pyramid is useful for visualizing levels.
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Q4: What is the Hierarchy of Needs? Explain each level.

Answer:

Maslow's Hierarchy of Needs is a pyramid of human needs arranged from basic to highest:

1. **Physiological needs** – food, water, sleep (basic survival)
2. **Safety needs** – protection from harm, job security
3. **Love and belongingness** – relationships, friendships, family
4. **Self-esteem** – confidence, respect, recognition
5. **Self-actualization** – reaching full potential, personal growth

Explanation:

Humans start by fulfilling the bottom needs. Only when these are satisfied can they focus on higher-level needs. Most people stay in lower levels, while few reach self-actualization.

Example:

A poor student will focus on food and shelter before worrying about joining a sports club or achieving personal dreams.

Tips:

- Use **pyramid analogy** in answers.
 - Mention **“lower before higher”** clearly.
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Q5: What is Self-Actualization?

Answer:

Self-actualization is the highest level of Maslow’s hierarchy, where a person reaches their full potential, grows freely, and becomes the best version of themselves in all areas of life.

Explanation:

It is about personal development, creativity, and realizing your unique talents. Self-actualized people understand themselves, accept weaknesses, and focus on meaningful goals.

Example:

Quaid-e-Azam, Dr Abdul Salam, or Javed Miandad are examples of people who achieved self-actualization because they fulfilled their potential in leadership, science, or sports.

Tips:

- Key idea: **“Being the best version of yourself.”**
 - Mention that **few people reach this level.**
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Q6: What are the basic concepts of Humanistic Psychology?

Answer:

The main concepts are:

1. **Individual as an integrated whole** – mind, body, and emotions are connected.
2. **Irrelevance of animal research** – humans are too complex to study only via animals.
3. **Human inner nature** – humans are naturally good.
4. **Human creative potential** – everyone has the ability to create and innovate.
5. **Maslow's Hierarchy of Motivation** – people are motivated by needs from basic to self-actualization.

Explanation:

Humanistic psychology looks at the **whole person** and emphasizes **growth, creativity, and self-understanding** rather than just mental illness.

Example:

A person writing poetry or inventing solutions demonstrates human creative potential.

Tips:

- Use simple keywords: **"whole person, growth, creativity, needs pyramid."**
- Focus on **positivity and personal development**.

Q7: Why can't all people achieve self-actualization?

Answer:

Not everyone achieves self-actualization because:

- many struggle with lower-level needs (food, safety, relationships)
- society or circumstances may block growth
- personal failures, low confidence, or lack of opportunity
- few people continuously work toward growth

Explanation:

Self-actualization is rare because life challenges, responsibilities, and social pressures prevent many from reaching full potential. Only people who fulfill basic

needs and actively grow can reach it.

Example:

A person who spends life worrying about money may never reach self-actualization even if they have talent.

Tips:

- Highlight **"basic needs first, then higher growth."**
 - Mention it's **rare and requires effort.**
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Q8: What are characteristics of Self-Actualizers?

Answer:

Self-actualizing individuals usually have these traits:

1. Efficient perception of reality – see things as they are
2. Acceptance of self and others – respect weaknesses
3. Spontaneity and simplicity – natural behavior
4. Problem centered – focus on meaningful goals
5. Privacy and detachment – enjoy solitude
6. Autonomy – rely on inner resources
7. Freshness of appreciation – enjoy life's small things
8. Peak experiences – moments of joy or insight
9. Social interest – care for humanity
10. Deep relationships – close, meaningful connections
11. Democratic attitude – respect everyone
12. Clear moral values – know right and wrong
13. Philosophical humor – laugh at life's absurdities
14. Creativeness – original and imaginative thinking
15. Resistance to enculturation – think independently of society

Explanation:

Self-actualizers are balanced, creative, independent, and focus on growth. They are not perfect but work toward meaningful goals and enjoy life deeply.

Example:

Einstein or Lincoln displayed creativity, independence, and deep concern for society.

Tips:

- Highlight **"seeing reality, growth, creativity, independence."**
 - Explain briefly each trait in 1–2 sentences in exams.
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Q9: Are Self-Actualizers Perfect?**Answer:**

No. Self-actualizers are human and can be irritable, stubborn, selfish, or moody. They are not immune to ordinary human weaknesses.

Explanation:

Even highly developed people have flaws. Self-actualization does not mean perfection; it means striving to reach full potential despite imperfections.

Example:

A creative genius may be impatient or moody but still achieves extraordinary results.

Tips:

- Emphasize **"human, not angelic."**
 - Show understanding of both strengths and weaknesses.
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Q10: What is the goal of psychotherapy in Humanistic Psychology?**Answer:**

The goal of psychotherapy is to help a person grow, restore personal potential, and return to the path of self-actualization by understanding themselves,

accepting feelings, and making responsible life choices.

Explanation:

Therapy supports personal development rather than just treating mental illness. It encourages self-awareness, free choice, and meaningful living.

Example:

A therapist may guide a student to overcome fear of failure so they can pursue their dreams.

Tips:

- Focus on **“growth, self-awareness, and personal choice.”**
- Avoid describing therapy only as treatment of illness.

True/False MCQs

Q1: Humanistic psychology focuses primarily on abnormal behavior rather than personal growth.

Answer: False

Explanation: Humanistic psychology focuses on positive aspects of life, personal growth, and self-actualization rather than just problems.

Q2: Maslow believed that humans are inherently good and have an inner drive to grow.

Answer: True

Explanation: A central idea of humanistic psychology is that people are naturally good and motivated to reach their potential.

Q3: Self-actualization can only be achieved if all lower-level needs are fully satisfied.

Answer: True

Explanation: According to Maslow, higher-level needs (like self-actualization) only emerge when basic needs (physiological, safety, love, esteem) are met.

Q4: Self-actualizers are perfect individuals free from weaknesses.

Answer: False

Explanation: Self-actualizers are still human and may have ordinary flaws like impatience or moodiness.

Conceptual MCQs

Q5: Which of the following best describes Humanistic Psychology?

- A. Behavior is controlled only by rewards and punishments
- B. Human behavior is motivated by unconscious conflicts
- C. Humans are basically good and motivated to grow
- D. Behavior is determined entirely by genetics

Answer: C

Explanation: Humanistic psychology emphasizes free will, personal growth, and the natural goodness of humans.

Q6: Which level of Maslow's hierarchy involves relationships and friendships?

- A. Safety needs
- B. Love and belongingness needs
- C. Self-esteem needs
- D. Self-actualization

Answer: B

Explanation: Love and belongingness needs focus on forming relationships, friendships, family bonds, and social connections.

Q7: Which of the following is NOT considered a characteristic of self-actualizers?

- A. Efficient perception of reality
- B. Detachment and need for privacy
- C. Dependence on external validation
- D. Peak experiences

Answer: C

Explanation: Self-actualizers rely on their inner resources and are independent of external approval.

Q8: The focus of Humanistic Psychology on studying “healthy persons” rather than “sick persons” is referred to as:

- A. Pathology approach
- B. Holistic approach
- C. Empirical validation
- D. Behaviorist approach

Answer: B

Explanation: Humanistic psychology takes a holistic approach, studying the complete person and their potential rather than only illness.

Situational/Applied MCQs

Q9: A student spends most of their time worrying about food and rent, and cannot focus on joining a sports club. According to Maslow, this student is likely:

- A. At the self-actualization level
- B. Fulfilling love and belongingness needs
- C. Focused on physiological needs
- D. Experiencing peak experiences

Answer: C

Explanation: The student’s focus on food and rent shows that their **physiological needs** are not fully satisfied, so higher-level needs cannot dominate.

Q10: A person chooses to volunteer to help street children, despite having no financial gain, because it aligns with their personal values. This behavior demonstrates:

- A. Obedience to authority
- B. Problem-centered focus and self-actualization
- C. Basic safety needs
- D. Dependence on society

Answer: B

Explanation: Self-actualizers often focus on meaningful goals beyond personal gain, showing problem-centered behavior.

Q11: A young adult refuses to accept mistakes at work and blames everyone else. Humanistic psychologists would say this person:

- A. Has reached self-actualization
- B. Is avoiding personal responsibility
- C. Is motivated by peak experiences
- D. Has fulfilled love and belongingness needs

Answer: B

Explanation: Abnormal or problematic behavior occurs when a person avoids responsibility for their actions and thoughts.

Q12: During therapy, a psychologist encourages a client to explore their inner potential, understand feelings, and pursue meaningful goals. This type of therapy is:

- A. Cognitive-behavioral therapy
- B. Psychoanalysis
- C. Humanistic psychotherapy
- D. Classical conditioning

Answer: C

Explanation: Humanistic therapy focuses on self-growth, self-understanding, and returning the person to the path of self-actualization.

Mixed/Tricky MCQs

Q13: Which of the following statements is true?

- A. Humanistic psychology considers animal research essential for understanding humans.
- B. Maslow believed self-actualization is easily achieved by most people.
- C. Self-actualizers often experience "peak experiences," moments of intense joy or insight.

D. Humanistic psychology focuses only on pathology and dysfunction.

Answer: C

Explanation: Self-actualizers frequently experience peak experiences. Humanistic psychology does **not** focus on pathology or animal research for understanding humans.

Q14: Maslow divided people into categories for study. Which is correct?

- A. Only self-actualizers
- B. Fairly sure cases, partial cases, potential cases
- C. Children, adults, elderly
- D. Sick, healthy, cured

Answer: B

Explanation: Maslow studied **fairly sure, partial, and potential cases** to understand self-actualization in different levels of growth.

Q15: Which of the following is an example of autonomy in self-actualizers?

- A. Relying entirely on teachers to guide learning
- B. Depending on friends for confidence
- C. Learning independently even if the environment is not ideal
- D. Avoiding difficult tasks to prevent failure

Answer: C

Explanation: Self-actualizers are autonomous and rely on their inner resources, not external conditions.

Q16: Which statement reflects a "democratic character" in self-actualizers?

- A. They follow rules blindly
- B. They respect and learn from everyone regardless of status
- C. They ignore others' opinions entirely
- D. They seek social approval for every action

Answer: B

Explanation: Self-actualizers respect all people and are open to learning from anyone.

Cheat Sheet

1. Key Terms & Definitions

Term	Definition	Example / Tip
Humanistic Psychology	Focus on positive aspects of life, free choice, personal growth, and human potential.	Think: <i>Humans are naturally good & can grow.</i>
Abnormality	Unhealthy or unhelpful behavior due to avoiding responsibility.	Blaming others for your mistakes.
Free Choice	Ability to decide independently.	Choosing a career you love.
Personal Growth	Self-improvement mentally, emotionally, socially.	Learning a new skill to improve yourself.
Self-Actualization	Highest potential; becoming the best version of yourself.	Quaid-e-Azam, Dr Abdul Salam.
Physiological Needs	Basic survival: food, water, sleep.	Hunger, thirst.
Safety Needs	Protection from danger; job/home security.	Wearing a helmet while riding.
Love & Belongingness	Relationships, friendship, acceptance.	Joining a club, making friends.
Self-Esteem Needs	Respect, confidence, recognition.	Winning a competition, promotion at work.
Peak Experiences	Moments of intense joy or insight.	Feeling ecstatic when solving a problem.
Autonomy	Reliance on inner resources, independence.	Learning without needing perfect conditions.
Holistic Approach	Studying mind, body, emotions together.	"Whole person" perspective.

2. Maslow's Hierarchy of Needs (Mnemonic + Table)

Mnemonic: "PSLSA" → Please Stop Loving Super Achievements

- **P:** Physiological
- **S:** Safety
- **L:** Love & Belongingness
- **S:** Self-Esteem
- **A:** Self-Actualization

Level	Needs	Tip / Example
1	Physiological	Food, water, sleep
2	Safety	Home, job, protection
3	Love & Belonging	Friendship, family, social bonds
4	Self-Esteem	Recognition, confidence, respect
5	Self-Actualization	Full potential, creativity, meaningful goals

Tip: Lower needs must be fulfilled before higher needs appear.

3. Characteristics of Self-Actualizers (Simple Mnemonic)

Mnemonic: "RAP PAF ST DC CC"

- **R** – Reality perception efficient
- **A** – Acceptance of self & others
- **P** – Problem-centered
- **P** – Privacy / Detachment
- **A** – Autonomy
- **F** – Freshness of appreciation
- **S** – Social interest
- **T** – Peak experiences / Transcendence

- **D** – Deep relationships
- **C** – Creativeness
- **C** – Clear moral standards

Tip: Use **short phrases** for quick recall.

4. Tips for Remembering Key Ideas

1. **Humanistic** = **Happy humans** → growth, free choice, creativity.
2. **Self-actualization** = **"Top of the pyramid"** → think: **"be your best self."**
3. **Abnormality** = **avoiding responsibility.**
4. **Peak experiences** = **"Wow moments"** → joy, insight, ecstasy.
5. **Autonomy** = **Inner power > External validation.**

5. Quick Examples for Exams

Concept	Example
Physiological Needs	Hungry student thinking about lunch instead of homework
Safety Needs	Living in a secure home vs. unsafe neighborhood
Love & Belonging	Joining a friend group or family bonding
Self-Esteem	Recognition in school or work
Self-Actualization	Dr Abdul Salam achieving scientific excellence
Peak Experience	Feeling inspired by a beautiful sunset or creative work
Autonomy	Learning a skill independently without a teacher

6. Exam Shortcuts / Tricks

- **Hierarchy** = **pyramid** → **visualize bottom to top.**
- **Characteristics of self-actualizers** → **group in 3s** or use mnemonic.
- **True/False shortcut:** Anything about **"humans are naturally good / self-growth"** = **True**; anything about **"perfect humans / only studying**

abnormality" = False.

- **Situational MCQs tip:** Check **which need is active** (low-level vs high-level).
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7. Quick Notes / Memory Hooks

- **Humanistic = Human growth focus**
 - **Maslow = Needs Pyramid** → *Survival* → *Safety* → *Love* → *Esteem* → *Self-actualization*
 - **Self-Actualizers = Realistic, autonomous, problem-centered, creative**
 - **Therapy goal = Restore self-growth path**
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8. Bonus Tiny Visual for Quick Scan

Maslow Pyramid (bottom →top)

Physiological

Safety

Love & Belonging

Self-Esteem

Self-Actualization

- Few reach the top.
- Lower needs must be satisfied first.
- Peak experiences often at top level.